

Session 11: The Rebellion of the Sons of Adam

Key Takeaways

- Being in covenant with God has nothing to do with being ethnically a part of Abraham's family. It means imitating Abraham's trust in God.
- The outcry of the ruined land is a key motif showing us how human corruption and suffering prompts God to act.
- The flood is part of the biblical pattern where we see God's judgment and his mercy at work simultaneously.

The Rebellion of the Sons of Adam: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 6:5-12

The Rebellion of the Sons of Adam

a 5 **And Yahweh saw** that **multiplied (רב)** was the badness of **humanity** **in the land** ,
b and every purpose of the plans of **his heart** was only bad all the day,

a' 6 and Yahweh **regretted that he made** **humanity** **in the land** .
b' And he was pained in **his heart**.

7 **And Yahweh said** ,
"I will wipe away **humanity** that I created from the face of **the ground** ,
from **humanity**
to animals
to creeping things
and to birds of the skies
for **I regret that I have made** them."

8 And/But Noah found favor **in the eyes of Yahweh**.

a 9 These are the **birth**-generations of Noah;
Noah was a righteous one,
b blameless in his generation;

Noah walked with *Elohim*;
 a 10 and Noah **birthed** three sons: Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

a 11 And **the land** was **ruined** *before Elohim*.
 b And **the land** was filled with violence,
 a' 12 and *Elohim saw* **the land** : and behold, **it** was **ruined**,
 b' for **all flesh** had **ruined** its/his way upon **the land** .

Genesis 6:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The Righteous One is Delivered from Death

Noah is described with two new terms (righteous and blameless), and one term already used of Enoch (walked with God). The analogy between Noah and Enoch has a clear purpose.

Life and Outcome	Enoch	Noah
"walked with God"	5:22 and Enoch walked with God three hundred years after he became the father of Methuselah, and he caused the birth of sons and daughters, ²³ and all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years. ²⁴ And Enoch walked with God ;	6:9 Noah was a righteous one, blameless in his generation; Noah walked with God .
Delivered from death	²⁴ and he was not, for God took him.	Rescued from death through the ark
<i>Life and Outcome of Enoch and Noah</i> . Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).		

The goal of this analogy is to fill out the picture of what it means to walk with God.

- Just as Enoch walked with God and was delivered from death, so Noah walks with God and is delivered from death.
- Just as Enoch walked with God, so Noah was righteous and blameless.

Genesis 17:1 NASB

Now when Abram was ninety-nine years old, the LORD appeared to Abram and said to him, "I am God Almighty; **walk before me**, and be **blameless**.

Genesis 24:40 NASB*

[Abraham] said to me, “**Yahweh, before whom I have walked**, will send his angel with you to make your journey successful, and you will take a wife for my son from my relatives and from my father’s house”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 48:15 NASB

[Jacob] blessed Joseph, and said, “The God **before whom my fathers Abraham and Isaac walked**, the God who has been my shepherd all my life to this day”

To be righteous means to do right by Yahweh, by trusting and following his wisdom; to do right by one’s neighbor; to be blameless means to live with ethical integrity, as a morally “whole” person.

Genesis 15:5-6 NASB

⁵ And he took him outside and said, “Now look toward the heavens, and count the stars, if you are able to count them.” And he said to him, “So shall your descendants be.” ⁶ Then he believed in the LORD; and he **reckoned it to him as righteousness**.

Psalms 15:1-3 NASB

¹ O LORD, who may abide in your tent?
Who may dwell on your holy hill?

² **He who walks with blamelessness, and practices righteousness**,
and speaks truth in his heart.

³ He does not slander with his tongue,
nor does evil to his neighbor,
nor takes up a reproach against his friend

This opening scene of the flood narrative shows a density of key words that will become thematic for the flood design pattern throughout the Hebrew Bible. All of the words are keyed off the scene of Noah’s birth name in 5:29.

Genesis 5:29 NASB*

And [Lamech] called his name **Noah (נח)** saying, “This one will **give us comfort (נחם)** from our work and from the toil of our hands from the ground which the LORD has cursed.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 6:5-13 Instructor's Translation

⁵ And Yahweh saw that multiplied was the badness of humanity in the land,
and every **purpose (מחשבת)** of the plans of his heart was only bad all the day,

⁶ and Yahweh **regretted (נחם)** that he made humanity in the land,
and he was pained in his heart.

⁷ And Yahweh said,
“I **will wipe away (מחה)** humanity that I created from the face of the ground,
from humanity to animals to creeping things and to birds of the skies
for I **regret (נחם)** that I have made them.”

⁸ But **Noah** (נח) found **favor** (חן) in the eyes of Yahweh.

⁹ These are the birth-generations of **Noah** (נח);
Noah (נח) was a righteous one,
 blameless in his generation;
Noah (נח) walked with *Elohim*;
¹⁰ and **Noah** (נח) birthed three sons: Shem, **Ham** (חם), and Japheth.

¹¹ And the land was **ruined** (שחת) before *Elohim*,
 and the land was filled with **violence** (חמס)
¹² and *Elohim* saw the land: and behold,
 it was **ruined** (נשחת) for all flesh had **ruined** (שחת) its/his way upon the land.

¹³ And *Elohim* said to **Noah** (נח) “The end of all flesh has come before me,
 because the land is filled with **violence** (חמס) because of them,
 and behold, I am going to **ruin** (משחית) the land.”

Key Theme Word Associations

Key Theme	Word Associations
comfort/regret (nakh am / ך	Noah (n oa kh / נח) favor (kh e n / חן) ruined (n ish kh at / נשחת)
comfort/regret (na kham / נחם)	purpose (m a kh shevet / מחשבת) wipe away (m a kh ah / מחשבת) Ham (kh a m / חם) violence (kh a m as / חמס) ruin (m ash kh it / משחית)
Genesis 6 Wordplay. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

The wordplay associations are dense and point to the main themes of the flood story as a whole.

Summary: Despite the evil **purposes** and **violence** of humanity that have **ruined** the land, and despite God’s **regret** and his decree to accelerate the **ruin** of the land, God views *Noah*, the man of *rest*, with *favor*, and delivers him to *bring comfort*.

Righteous Noah, a Ruined World, and a Regretful God

The violence in the land is directly connected to the preceding two narratives in 4:1-26 and 6:1-4. Both narratives highlight the role of human and cosmic violence and disorder in the land.

Narrative 1	Narrative 2
Genesis 4:3-16 • Cain murders his brother • Abel’s innocent blood “cries out from the ground”	Genesis 6:5-6, 11-12 ⁵ and Yahweh saw that multiplied was the badness of humanity in the land, and every purpose (מחשבת) of the plans of his heart was only bad all the day, ⁶ and Yahweh regretted (נחם) that he made humanity in the land, and he was pained in his heart. ¹¹ And the land was ruined (שחת) before Elohim, and the land was filled with violence (חמס), ¹² and Elohim saw the land: and behold, it was ruined (נשחת) , for all flesh had ruined (שחת) its/his way upon the land.
Genesis 4:17-26 • Cain’s city • Lemek murders without mercy	
Genesis 6:1-4 • Sons of God commit sexual violence against human women • Nephilim are violent warriors • In the land	
<i>Violence in the Land Preceding Genesis 6:5-6, 11-12. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>	

Yahweh's decision is one of grief, sadness, and emotional pain. He must respond to the outcry of innocent blood when it soaks the land, so he enacts a decree to purify the land of the defilement of bloodshed. This is a key pattern that runs throughout the Hebrew Bible.

Numbers 35:33-34 NASB

³³ So you shall not **pollute the land** in which you are; for **blood pollutes the land** and no **purification can be made for the land for the blood that is shed on it**, except by the blood of him who shed it. ³⁴ So you shall not **defile the land** in which you live, in the midst of which I dwell; for I the LORD am dwelling in the midst of the sons of Israel.

Two Divine Warnings About the Flood (Gen. 6:13-7:5)

God's speech to Noah comes in two parallel panels that overlap and differ in the way that Hebrew poetic lines do.

Divine Speech #1: Translation and Literary Design of 6:13-22

Command

¹³ And Elohim said to Noah,

Announcement of the Flood

"The end of **all flesh** has come before me,
because the land is filled with violence because of them,
and behold, I am going to ruin them with the land.

Directions for Deliverance by Making the Ark

- a 14 **Make** for yourself **an ark** of **gopher (גפר)** trees;
b you will **make** **the ark** of reeds,
a' and you will **pitch (כפר)** it inside and out with **pitch (כפר)**.

15 This is how you will **make** it:
300 cubits: the length of **the ark**
50 cubits: its width
30 cubits: its height.

- a 16 You will **make** a window for **the ark**,
b' and you will finish it to a cubit from the top;
a' and you will set the door of **the ark** in its side;
b' with lowers, seconds, and thirds you will **make** it.

Announcement of the Flood

17 **And as for me, behold, I am going to** bring the flood of water upon the land,
to ruin all flesh, which has in it the breath of life, from under the skies,
everything that is on the land will expire.

Directions for Deliverance by Entering the Ark

- a 18 **And I will set up my covenant with you [see 9:8-17]**
b and you will **go** into **the ark**,
c you and your sons and your wife, and your sons' wives with you.
c' 19 And of every living thing of **all flesh**,
b' two of everything you will make **go** into **the ark**,
a **to keep them alive** with you;
b they shall be **male and female**,
c 20 **of the birds after their kind**,
c' **and of the animals after their kind**,
c'' **of every creeping thing of the ground after its kind**,
b' **two of every kind** will **go** to you
a' **to keep them alive**.
a 21 And as for you, take for yourself some of all **edible-food** that you will eat,
b' and gather it to yourself;

a' and it shall be for **edible-food** for yourself and for them."

Fulfillment

22 And Noah did
according to all that Elohim had commanded him,
so he did.

Genesis 6:13-22. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Observations on Speech #1

- The unit begins and ends with a report of command and fulfillment.
- There are two announcements of the flood as a divine initiative, each followed by a call from God to Noah that Noah initiate a response. First to make the ark, the vehicle of his deliverance, and second to fill the ark with his family, the animals, and food.

God's Purpose in Bringing the Flood (Gen. 6:11-13)

As noted in 6:5-7, God's decision to bring the flood was not motivated by anger, but by grief. This portrait is filled out in an important way in 6:11-13, which transitions from the narrative of creation's corruption to God's response and address to Noah.

Point of View	Parallel Statements
Narrator's report of the land's corruption	11 And the land was ruined before <i>Elohim</i>, and the land was filled with violence , 12 and <i>Elohim</i> saw the land: and behold, it was ruined , for all flesh had caused the ruin of its way upon the land.
God's words to Noah recall the narrative report	13 And <i>Elohim</i> said to Noah, "The end of all flesh has come before me, because the land is filled with violence because of them , and behold, I am going to cause their ruin with the land.
<i>God's Purpose in Bringing the Flood. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>	

Note the parallelism between "all flesh has caused the ruin of its way on the land" and "I am going to cause their ruin with the land." This shows that God's decision to bring the flood is interconnected with the disaster that humans are themselves choosing and perpetuating in the land. God's decision is not imposed from the outside. Rather, his decision is prompted by and works through humanity's self-enacted ruin in the land.

The wording of 6:13 is crucial: "The end of all flesh has come up right in front of me."

[God] “is not the subject of the clause [‘the end has come’] ... the notion is that the demise of all flesh has passed before [God] and so made itself evident. The Hebrew construction distances the deity from the decision making process, almost as if this outcome was inevitable.”

Bandstra, Barry (2008). [*Genesis 1-11: A Handbook on the Hebrew Text*](#). Baylor University Press. 358.

“The [verse] suggests that God has seen where the ruination of creation is headed and has decided to accelerate the process to its completion ... the plain sense of the Hebrew text conveys something very different from most English translations, which are perhaps influenced by the view of an angry, punitive deity. ... The flood was an ancient symbol of destruction and disorder, as so is a fitting medium for the dissolution of creation as it overwhelms every boundary and returns creation to the primordial undifferentiated ‘deep’ that existed before Yahweh spoke boundaries into being. ... We are left with the sense that God is not so much sending the flood to punish the world as much as facilitating, through the flood, the inevitable descent into chaos caused by human destructiveness and violence. God ruins an already ruined creation, and in so doing creates conditions for a reordering and a renewal to take place.”

Hawk, L. Daniel (2018). [*The Violence of the Biblical God: Canonical Narrative and Christian Faith*](#). Eerdmans. 32-33.

Reflection Question

What is God responding to that motivates him to send the flood?